Who Is Actually Clutch in the NBA?

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Research Question

We ask whether NBA players shoot better or worse in clutch situations than in their own non-clutch situations during the 2025–26 regular season. We define clutch using the NBA standard: the final five minutes of the fourth quarter or overtime when the pre-shot scoring margin is five points or fewer. For each player i, our comparison is $\Delta_i = p_{i,\text{clutch}} - p_{i,\text{nonclutch}}$; our initial hypothesis is that the two underlying shooting probabilities are equal.

Data

We obtained NBA play-by-play data for the completed 2025–26 regular season using the R package hoopR. Each record identifies the game and shooter and includes the period, game clock, team scores, shot value, and made/missed outcome needed to classify field-goal attempts; free throws were excluded. The available play-by-play covers 1,229 completed standard regular-season games. The exploratory analysis includes every player with at least one clutch field-goal attempt; the first figure displays the 20 players with the most clutch attempts so that individual comparisons remain readable.

Exploratory Analysis

Across the available games, 413 players attempted at least one clutch field goal. They combined for 7,138 clutch attempts, with a field-goal percentage of 43.5%, compared with 47.2% on non-clutch attempts.

The first figure connects each player's non-clutch and clutch percentages; points farther to the right represent higher observed shooting percentages. The second figure displays each player's observed difference, $\widehat{\Delta}_i$, against the number of clutch attempts. Points above zero indicate a higher observed clutch percentage, while points below zero indicate a lower observed clutch percentage. The attempt count shows how much clutch data supports each observed difference.

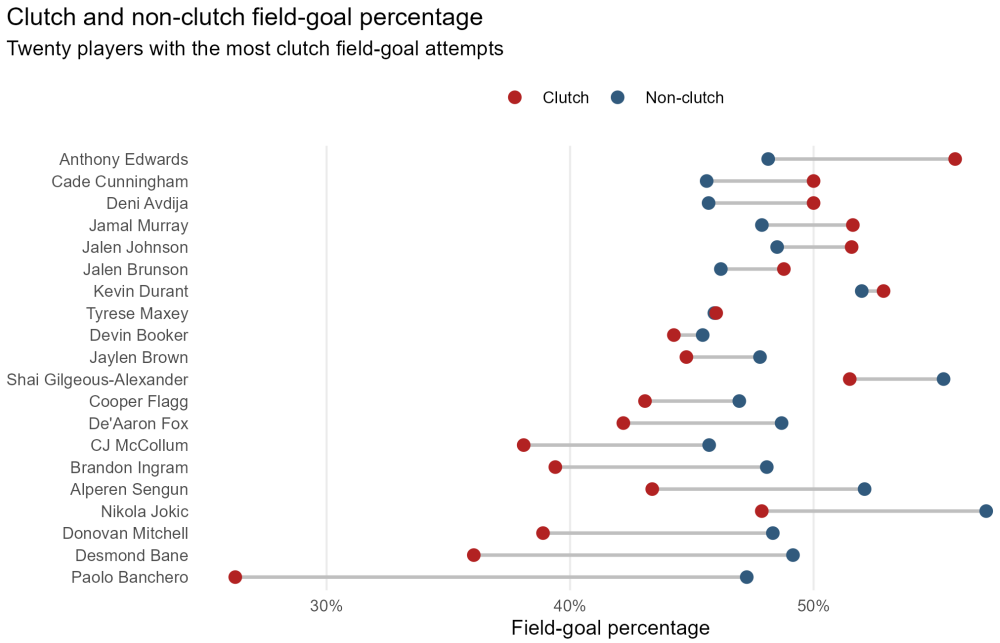


Figure 1: Clutch and non-clutch field-goal percentages for the 20 players with the most clutch attempts.

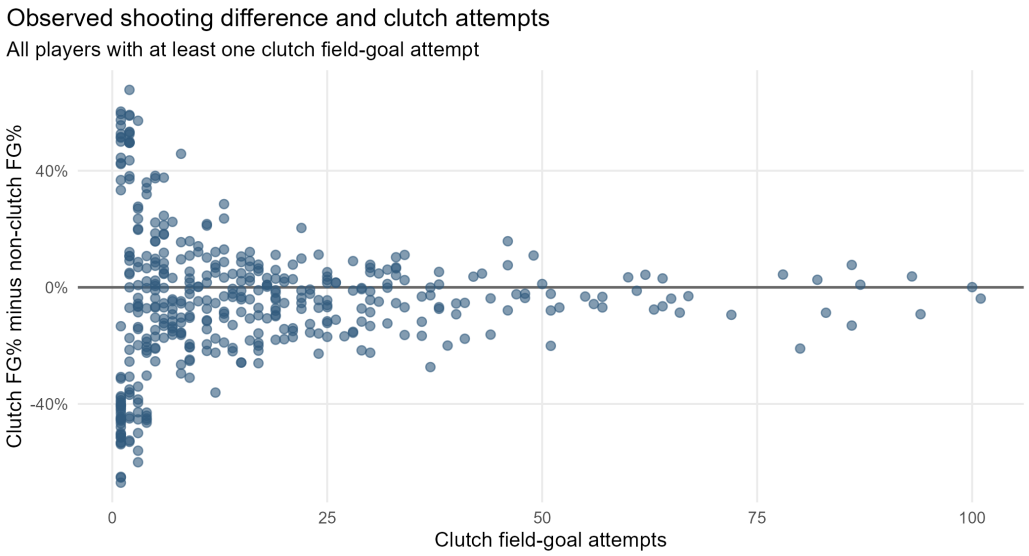


Figure 2: Observed shooting differences plotted against clutch field-goal attempts.